

MARKET INTELLIGENCE · BUILT ON RECEIPTS, NOT HYPE

Follow the Money.

1,000 startups, radically honest about what they actually earn — where the cash really lands, who's quietly winning in the shadows, and what nobody tells you before you quit your job to build the next big thing.

Source: TrustMRR — 1,000-row verified-revenue dataset, frozen July 30, 2026

Prepared for: Founder Strategy Review

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Four things worth knowing before you build



Revenue is a power law, not a bell curve

The top 10 companies capture ~50% of all revenue in the dataset. The median company earns just \$400/month — the average (\$15.6K) is a mirage created by a handful of outliers.



AI is the biggest sector — and the weakest per-founder bet

AI startups generate the most total revenue (\$2.36M) simply on volume (197 companies), but their median revenue (\$503) trails Education, Marketing, and Content Creation.



Education & Marketing offer the best risk-adjusted entry

Highest median revenue per company, and the lowest share of \$0-revenue startups — signals of real, monetizable demand rather than hype-driven noise.

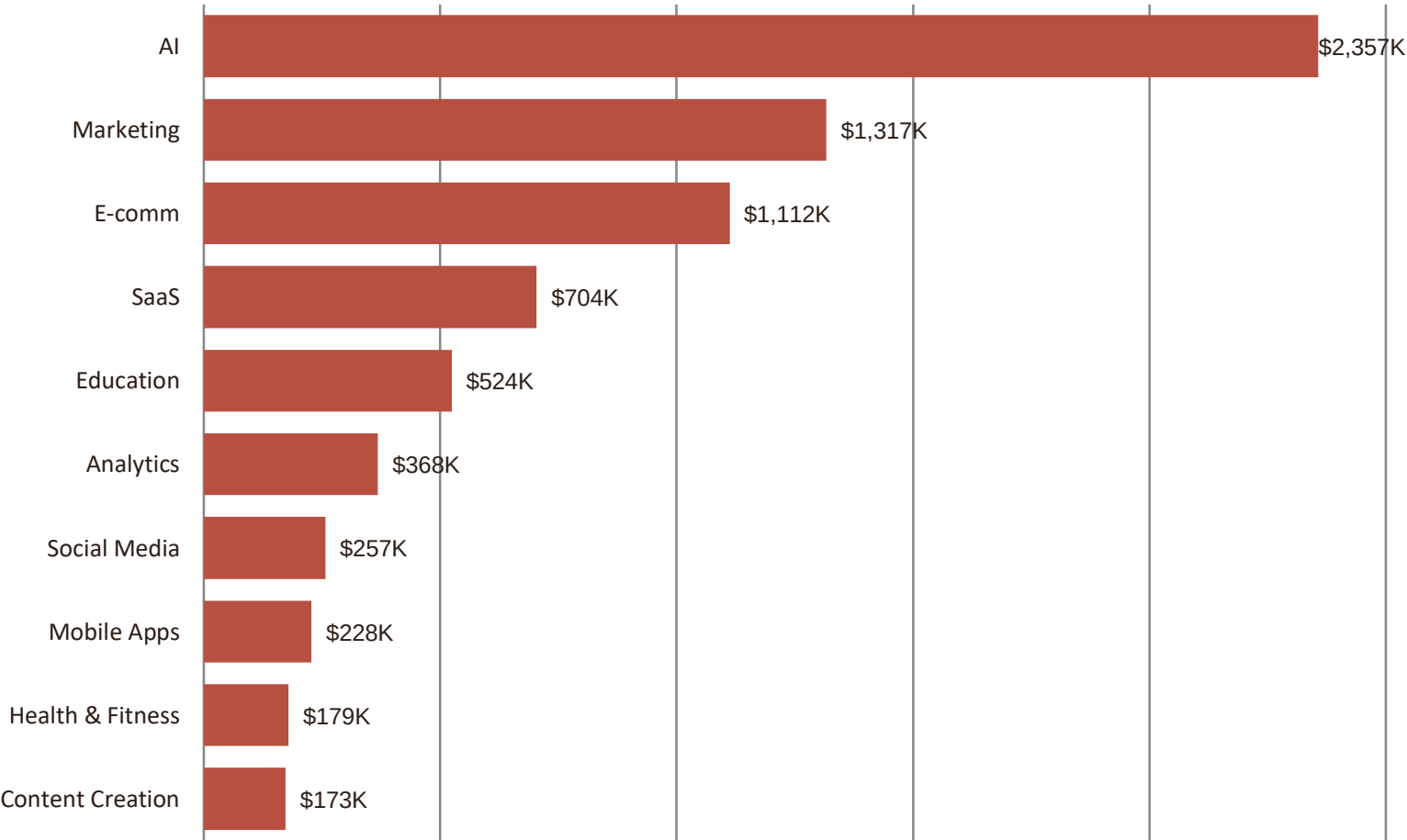


Stripe and RevenueCat are the trusted default

82% of every startup in the dataset runs on one of these two rails — Stripe for web SaaS, RevenueCat for mobile subscriptions. Everything else is a rounding error.

Follow the cash: who's making money today

Total 30-day revenue by category, top 10 of 29 — combined, these ten sectors represent 88% of all revenue in the dataset.



READ ON THE DATA

\$15.6M

total 30-day revenue across all 1,000 companies

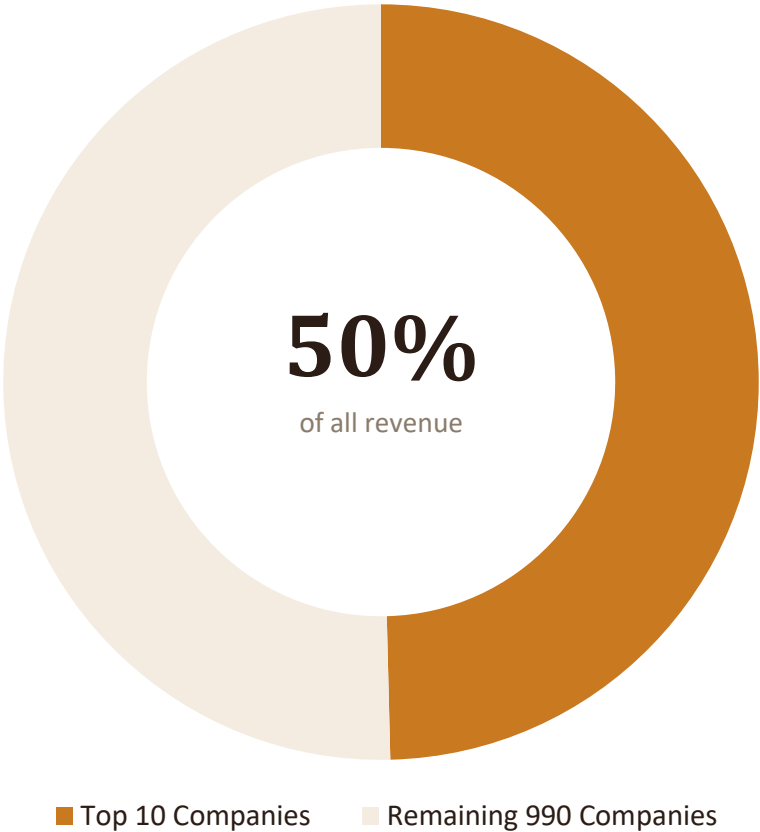
3

sectors — AI, Marketing, E-comm — drive over half of it

22%

of every company in the dataset earns \$0

The 1% problem hiding inside that big number



\$400

Median 30-day revenue

vs. a \$15.6K mean — the average is not a typical company

22%

Startups earning \$0

roughly 1 in 5 listings have zero revenue in the trailing 30 days

10

Companies

out of 1,000 that account for half of all revenue generated

Where the real odds are, not just the headlines

Sectors with ≥8 listed companies, ranked by median revenue per company — the number that matters more than category buzz.

Sector	# Companies	Median 30d Rev.	% Earning \$0	Verdict
Education	30	\$2,435	10.0%	Highest
Marketing	42	\$2,370	9.5%	Highest
Content Creation	36	\$1,238	8.3%	High
Sales	13	\$986	0.0%	High
Dev Tools	37	\$635	8.1%	Growing
AI	197	\$503	13.7%	Crowded

Highlighted rows = strongest risk-adjusted opportunity for a new entrant

Build in Education, Marketing, or Content Creation

Not because they're trendy — because the data shows real people already paying real money, without 197 competitors crowding the category.



Education — \$2,435 median revenue

Highest per-company payoff in the dataset, with only 30 competitors and just 10% earning nothing.



Marketing — \$2,370 median revenue

Nearly matches Education's payoff at higher volume (42 companies) — a validated, repeatable niche.



Content Creation — \$1,238 median revenue

Third-highest median revenue with the lowest zero-revenue rate (8.3%) of any sizeable category.



Watch: Dev Tools is the one sector actually growing

The only category with positive median MRR growth (+8.9% in 30 days) — worth tracking even if not the top pick today.

What nobody's telling you at the pitch night

Three signals the data surfaces that most founder advice completely ignores.



The quietest founders are winning the biggest

Startups hidden behind "Stealth Company" listings post a \$8,362 median 30-day revenue — 33x the \$253 median of publicly named companies. Going public early may be costing you more than it's earning you.



Your follower count is basically noise

X/Twitter followers correlate with revenue at just 0.02 — statistically nothing. Chasing an audience is not the same activity as building a business, and the data can't tell them apart either.



AI gets the hype; SaaS gets the wallet

Per visitor, SaaS products convert \$3.57 of revenue — ten times better than AI's \$0.36. AI wins on total dollars purely by having 6x more entrants, not because it monetizes attention better.

The shortcut nobody runs the numbers on

Everyone plans to build from zero. 261 listings in this dataset suggest a faster door: buy a business that's already making money.

\$35,000

Median asking price

for a for-sale company in this dataset with a stated price

\$1,074

Median MRR of those listings

already-flowing monthly revenue on day one of ownership

~38 mo.

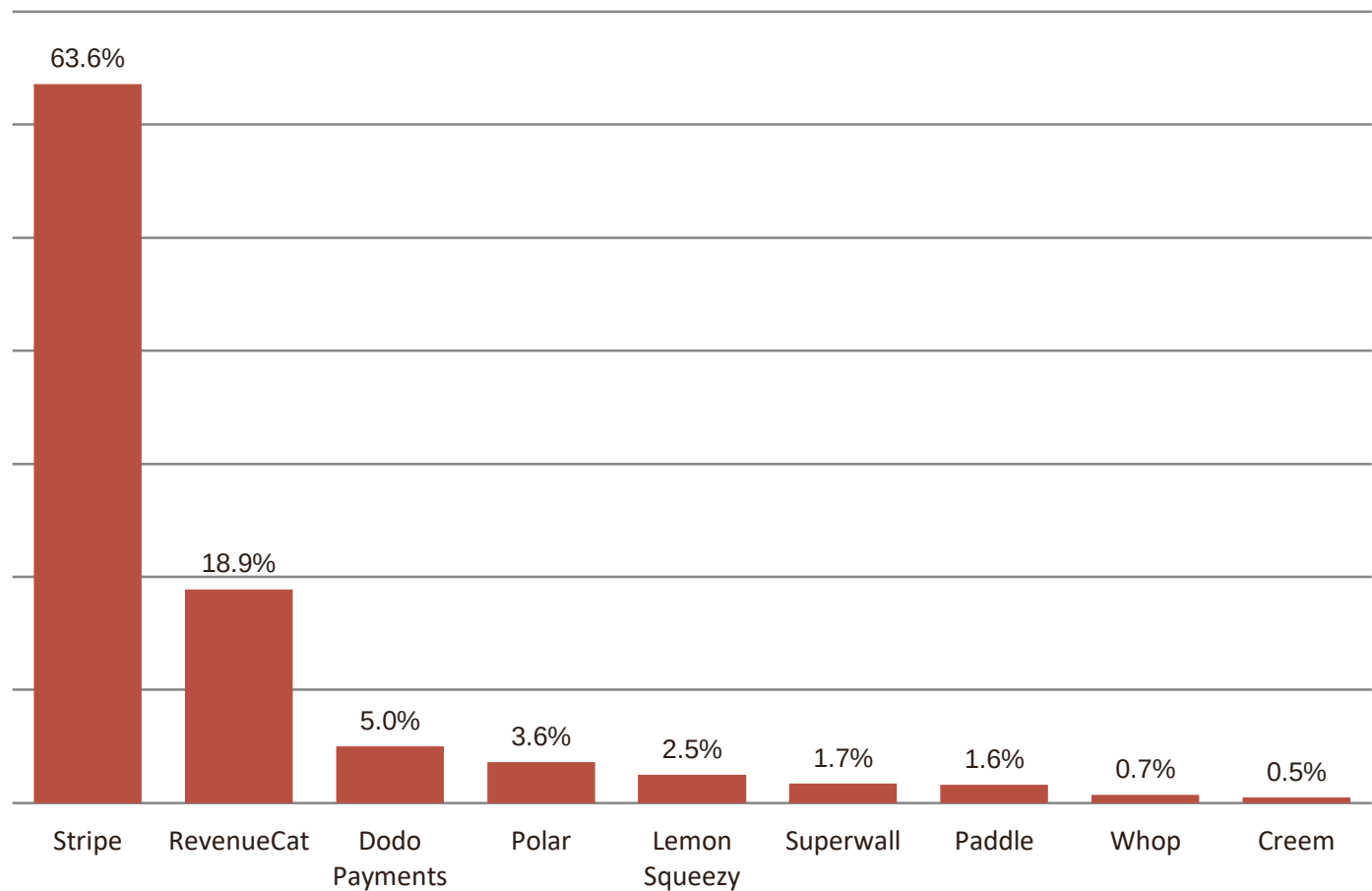
Median payback period

asking price $\div$ monthly revenue — the business pays for itself in about 3 years

Not a universal answer — due diligence risk, platform dependency, and founder fit still matter. But "build vs. buy" deserves the same 10 minutes of math as a new idea does.

Who founders actually trust with their money

Share of all 1,000 companies (single-provider listings, n=981) running on each payment gateway.



TWO GATEWAYS, 82% OF THE MARKET



Stripe — the default for web SaaS

63.6% adoption, \$734.50 median 30-day revenue — the highest of any high-adoption gateway.



RevenueCat — the default for mobile

18.9% adoption among subscription mobile apps; lowest zero-revenue rate (13.2%) of the big two.



Superwall — small but elite

Only 1.7% adoption, but the best performance of any gateway: \$2,999 median revenue, just 5.9% at \$0.

The fine print worth actually reading



It's a snapshot, not a trend line

Frozen July 30, 2026 — a single point in time. Category rankings can shift as new listings appear or fold.



Smaller categories are noisy

Categories under ~15 companies (Sales, Fintech, Security) can swing heavily on one or two outlier listings.



Listing bias toward sellers

TrustMRR skews toward founders actively marketing or selling their business — not a random sample of all startups.



Growth data is mostly flat by construction

Median 30-day MRR growth is 0% for nearly every category — real trajectory needs a longer time window than 30 days.

Your move, starting tomorrow morning

1

Pick Education, Marketing, or Content Creation

Highest median revenue per founder, and the lowest odds of ending up at \$0 — better unit economics than chasing the AI wave.

2

Price your idea against buying one instead

\$35K medians buy a business already earning \$1,074/month. Run that math before writing a line of code.

3

Build on Stripe from day one

It's the market standard for a reason — 63.6% adoption and the strongest revenue profile among high-adoption rails. Add RevenueCat only if you ship mobile.

4

Ignore your follower count; watch your revenue per visitor

Audience size barely correlates with revenue ($r=0.02$) — track conversion, not vanity metrics.

Go build. Or go buy. Just follow the money.

Questions on the methodology, or want a custom cut of this data for a specific category or country?

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